Homecoming King

By Hasan Minhaj

HASAN: My parents physically never saw each other. Years ago in a town in India, population 990,000 — that's a small town — my dad heard a buzz in the streets about this woman named Seema, my mom. And, Seema was like the iPhone *[insert latest iPhone model here].* "Have you heard of Seema? She's slim. Her family owns a camera." My dad was like, "A camera?" So, he runs to my grandfather's house and lays it on the line. "I'm going to America. I want to marry Seema." In ten minutes, the man married a woman he had never laid eyes on.

INTRODUCTION

Named to TIME's "100 Most Influential People in the World," Hasan Minhaj is a 1st generation American whose Muslim family immigrated her from India before he was born. And although he got his start as a stand-up comedian, he has come to be known for much more than his comedy. He draws on his personal history and the immigrant experience to explore America's modern cultural and political landscape with depth and sincerity.

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*In fact, according to Lauren Feldman, associate professor at Rutgers' School of Communication and Information, it is just this type of boundary-pushing "comedy [that] can play an important role in challenging people to address critical social issues." **

I give you . . . Homecoming King by Hasan Minhaj

HASAN: So. my dad marries my mom, they come to the States, they have me, in Davis, California. But Davis was, like, super white. Roll call was a problem. It was a big deal for a lot of us. I would get, like, "Hanson Minaja . . . Sahan Minha . . . Saddam Hussein." *[beat]* I'm not Saddam.

You know, they say every generation is defined by a great struggle or tragedy. So when 9-11 happened I was in high school. My dad sits everybody down. He's like, "Hasan, whatever you do, do not tell people you're Muslim or talk about politics."

"Alright, Dad, I'll just hide it. This *[gestures to his skin color]* just rubs off."

We're sitting there. Phone rings. I run, but my dad beats me to the phone. "Hello?"

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I grab the second phone. I hear a voice. “Hey, you sand n*gger, where’s Osama?” He looks at me. “You can hear me, right? You dune coon. Where’s Osama? Hey, 2631 Regatta Lane, that’s where you live, right? I’m going to kill you.” Click.

And my dad’s looking at me. Do you ever see your parents, and you see the mortality in them? I’m looking at my dad and I see all five-seven of him. And that’s when I realize I’m a ***darapok***. I’m a scaredy-cat.

We can speak two languages! I should have said something. I didn’t. We sit down. I hear “thud, thud, thud” outside. Me and Dad run outside and all the windows on the Camry, the immigrant car of choice, are smashed in. My backpack’s open. “They stole my stuff.” I’m mad. They know where we live, they’re timing this, so they’re watching us. I’m looking in the trees, the bushes . . . I look back, and my dad is in the middle of the road sweeping glass out of the road like he works at a barbershop.

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“We’ve got customers. ***Log kya kahenge*****?** We’ve got to clean this up.” Zen! Brown Mr Miyagi, just, like, not saying a word.

I’m like, “Why aren’t you saying something? I’m asking you, say something!”

He looks at me and goes, “Hasan. . . These things happen, and these things will continue to happen. That’s the price we pay for being here.”

We really are from two different generations. My dad’s from that generation where he feels like if you come to this country, you pay the American dream tax. You endure racism, and if it doesn’t cost you your life, pay it. There you go, Uncle Sam. But for me, I was born here. So I actually have the audacity of equality. I’m like, “I’m in Honors Gov. *[takes out text book]* I have it right here. Life, liberty, pursuit of happiness. All men created equal.” It says it right here, I’m equal. I’m equal. I don’t deserve this.

But as soon as I say that, he looks at me like I believe in Santa. “Hasan, you’ll never understand.”

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"**I'll** never understand? Dad, you're the guy that will argue with the cashier at Costco when he doesn't let you return used underwear. And now you want to be the bigger man? Now you're like, 'Let's be reasonable with the bigots.' What?" And then he just walks back into the house with glass in his feet. And I honestly don't know who is more right. Maybe he's right. Put your head down. Be a doctor, get a house in the burbs, let them call them whatever you want. But isn't it our job to push the needle forward little by little? Isn't that how all this stuff happens? I don't know. The pendulum swings back and forth for me. And I know 9/11 is a super touchy subject. I understand. Because when it happened, everyone in America felt like their country was under attack. But on that night, September 12th, it was the first night of so many nights where my family's loyalty to this country was under attack.

As immigrants we always have to put on these press releases to prove our patriotism. We're auditioning. "We love this country, please believe me." Nobody loves this country more than us.

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I fell in love here. Six years old, Janice Malo. I saw her in the sandbox. I run up to her. First grade. "I love you!"

"You're the color of poop." That's memory number one.

In the third grade, Miss Anderson said, "Write what you want to be." Some kids were like, "an astronaut," or "a firefighter." I was like, "I want to be white."

So, by my senior year of high school, I had yet to go to a school dance, I had been cut from the basketball team, and I had just got off this medicine called Accutane so my skin and face was peeling. I'm crushing life. Out here, killing it. But there was one bright spot, this girl named Bethany Reed. Her family had just moved from Nebraska to Davis, and we were in AP Calc together, but… we had chemistry.

One night she was like, "Hey, we always study at my house. Why don't we study at your house?"

What, invite you over to my house? You walk in: "What language are you guys speaking? What's that smell?"

I'm not going to open myself up to that. But I was like, "No, she's different."

"Mom, Dad, a school friend is coming over. Everyone, please be normal."

My dad is like, "We are normal." Killing me, you know what I mean? "Hasan, we're normal. Be proud. You should be proud."

We get there. We're sitting at my living room table. My mom and dad are arguing in Hindi. My mom is frying pakoras. You've got to ease your way in. She's from Nebraska. It's all coming at this girl. It's too much. So, I'm looking at her, like, "Don't say anything. Please don't say anything." She looks up from her book, and she's like, "You know what? This is really nice. We should do this more often." And I look at her, and I'm like, "Oh, my God. I love you. You see me. I don't got to change who I am? I can be me!"

She's like, "Listen, you know, ever since my family moved from Nebraska, you've been my best friend. And you're really special to me. This year wouldn't be the

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same without you. So I was wondering, will you go to prom with me?"

The night of prom rolls around. I put on the JC Penney suit. Spray on the Michael Jordan cologne. Six puffs, one for each championship. You don't want to overkill it with the MJ cologne. Don't be tacky. I'm scaling down the side of my roof, scraping my knees. I jump off the roof. It's like 20 feet. I jump off, I somehow land, I get on my bike. It's beautiful, the sun is setting, it's one of those gorgeous evenings. And I'm biking with my knees bowed out. So my slacks don't get caught up in the chains. Fast enough to get there, but slow enough to not get pit stains. I'm balancing the corsage.

I get to her house. I park my bike. I'm walking up to the doorstep, and I'm about to ring the doorbell when I'm like, "Wait. 30 second time-out. Do you understand what's about to go down? You're about to go to prom with Bethany Reed. This is the American dream. This is what Dad fought for." Ding-dong.

Mrs. Reed opens the door. She has this look of concern. And I look over her shoulder, and I see Jeff Burke putting a corsage on Bethany's wrist. *(long beat)*

And she's like, "Oh, my God, honey, did Bethany not tell you? Sweetie, we love you, we think you're great. We love that you come over and study. But tonight is one of those nights . . . We have a lot of family back home in Nebraska and we're going to be taking photos, so we don't think you'd be a good fit. Do you need a ride home? Mr Reed can give you a ride home."

And I was like, "No, I have my bike." And I just biked home and played Mario Kart. That's the nicest I've ever been dressed, playing Mario Kart. *(long beat)* The sad part is, I felt bad for being there. Who was I to ruin their picture-perfect celebration? You've seen movies. How many times do you see that on screen? And it's not like they were yokels yelling "sand n*gger!" I could let that pass. I didn't know that people could be bigoted even as they were smiling at you. It's hard when you see people saying they love you but they're afraid at the same time. And I didn't know what that meant. *(long beat)*

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Maybe we have a race problem. There is bigotry that happens every day because we're too afraid of the Other. Someone who's not in our tribe. I wish I could tell 18-year-old me, "Hey, man, don't let this experience define you. It's good people and bad people. Irrespective of creed, class, color, find those good people. Because love is bigger than fear."

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Introduction Quote (Source)

Comedy Can Help Change the World, Rutgers Researcher Says. June 22, 2020.
https://www.rutgers.edu/news/comedy-can-help-change-world-rutgers-researcher-says

NOTE: ***Use Google Translate for help with pronunciation of Hindi words and phrases***

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